

₹20,000 when it comes to raw power. The iQOO Z9 is the fastest phone you can get your hands on under ₹20,000. And this is confirmed by a slew of benchmark scores. The phone scores 7,30,223 in AnTuTu v10, which even beats the Nothing Phone (2a) featuring the same processor. In GeekBench, the iQOO Z9 scores a whopping 1187 points in the Single Core test – higher than all its competitors. In the Multi-Core test, the POCO X6 5G pulls ahead, but it did launch at ₹22K. The phone also gets a score of 11649 in PCMark Work, which is pretty good.

In GPU benchmarks, there's no contesting its power. The phone outputted 4133 points in 3D Mark Wild Life and 1151 points in 3D Mark Wild Life Extreme, showcasing the potential of its GPU. In all the tests I ran in GFXBench, the iQOO Z9 once again came out on top.

Real-world performance is also top-notch. The phone showed no signs of throttling even under sustained workload, which is confirmed by the CPU Throttling Test scores where no throttling was detected. Everything from browsing social media to playing heavy-duty games runs smoothly here. You can even play Call of Duty: Mobile at 90 fps, and it's super smooth with minimal heat and frame skips. So, performance-wise, the iQOO Z9 can handle pretty much anything you throw at it.

Moving on to the UI, the iQOO Z9 comes with Funtouch OS 14 based on Android 14. The company offers two years of software updates and three years of security updates, which is standard at this price. Funtouch OS looks a bit clunky and comes with quite a bit of bloatware. It's not nearly as bad as some Realme phones, but third-party apps such as Snapchat, Netflix, Agoda, Candy Crush, and more are preinstalled. I hope iQOO fine-tunes its software more to meet 2024 standards in its future launches. Especially since the Nothing Phone (2a) with essentially no bloatware is available at ₹24K.

CAMERA

iQOO has done a fantastic job tuning the Z9's camera. The iQOO Z9 houses a 50-megapixel Sony IMX882 primary

sensor with OIS support. There's no ultrawide shooter, which is a bummer; you just get a nominal 2-megapixel depth shooter. Up front, you've got a 16-megapixel selfie camera as well. While the lack of an ultrawide camera can be jarring to some, the primary camera has improved by spades compared to the predecessor. The Sony IMX882 camera is capable of clicking some surprisingly stunning photos in daylight and low-light situations.

In daylight, the main camera clicks fantastic shots. Images look crisp, colours look surprisingly close to natural, and the shadows and highlights are well-exposed. The dynamic range is solid for the price, it compares to some ₹30-35K phones I've tested from last year. You can also click 2x in-sensor zoom images, and these look nearly indistinguishable from the 1x shots, which is very commendable. Close-up pictures are excellent too; with a natural bokeh effect.

The iQOO Z9 also allows you to click full 50-megapixel shots and the dynamic range doesn't take much of a hit here, which is great to see. Details are enhanced, especially when you pixel peep and the colours remain close to natural. There's also a macro mode, and you can click some half-decent shots here as well.

The iQOO Z9 shines when it comes to low-light photography. There's minimal noise and lens flare, and the results generally look very polished. The shadows may lack some detail, but you have to remember that this is a ₹20K phone, so it is a nitpick. Check out the low-light camera samples below, they look excellent for the price.

The selfie camera is decent, not the best pictures in low light, but daylight performance is definitely usable. The iQOO Z9 can also shoot 4K video with stabilisation, and it works wonders. So, good job here iQOO!

BATTERY LIFE

The iQOO Z9 comes with a large 5,000 mAh battery. According to iQOO, this is the biggest battery on an iQOO Z series smartphone yet. The battery life of the iQOO Z9 is better than the likes

of the Realme 12+ 5G but the Moto G84 does last longer. Nevertheless, I got a screen-on time of nearly 5-6 hours daily, which is pretty decent. My days consisted of clicking lots of pictures, browsing through social media, and some light gaming.

The phone has decent efficiency – one hour of GPS navigation drained the battery by about 9 per cent and 30 minutes of streaming Netflix depleted the battery by 6 per cent. The iQOO Z9 supports 44 W fast charging which charges the phone from zero to full in 74 minutes. This is much slower than the Realme 12+ which charges to full in just 48 minutes.

VERDICT

iQOO has turned up the throttle this year. A company once only focussed on performance has now come out with one of the best all-rounders in the sub-₹20,000 smartphone segment. The iQOO Z9 is a jack of all trades – it has the BEST performance under ₹20K, a fantastic primary camera that does extremely well in most conditions, and a gorgeous AMOLED display. The battery life is also pretty decent; it should easily last most users a full day. The only two areas where iQOO could step up more are design and UI. The design looks a bit cheaper than other similarly-priced options and the UI feels clunky and has quite a bit of bloatware. These are minor issues though. The iQOO Z9 is one of the easiest phones to recommend under ₹20K – it checks all the major boxes and is priced very competitively.

–Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: MediaTek Dimensity 7200 | GPU: Arm Mali-G610 | OS: Funtouch OS 14, Android 14 | RAM: 8 GB LPDDR4X | ROM: 128/256 GB UFS 2.2, Expandable up to 1 TB | Display: 6.67" FHD+ AMOLED | Display refresh rate: 120 Hz | Cameras (rear): 50 MP Sony IMX882 (OIS) + 2 MP bokeh | Camera (front): 16 MP | IP rating: IP54 | Battery capacity: 5,000 mAh | Charging: 44 W | Weight: 188 g | Colours: Brushed Green, Graphene Blue

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